

attended. He adopted the lifestyle of a country landowner, writing operas at a less frantic pace. Works such as *Un ballo in maschera* (1859) and *La forza del destino* (1862) showed a turn toward large-scale spectacle that reached its climax with *Aida*. This work was commissioned by Khedive Ismail, ruler of Egypt, who had built the Khedivial Opera House in Cairo to celebrate the opening of the Suez Canal in 1869. First performed in the Khedivial Opera House in 1871, *Aida* ensured its enduring popularity through the sumptuous exploitation of its exotic Ancient Egyptian setting.

Verdi did not compose a new opera for another 16 years. In 1874, he wrote his *Requiem Mass* for poet Alessandro Manzoni, which was described by the conductor Hans von Bülow as “an opera in ecclesiastical robes.” He also revamped older works and tinkered with plans, unfulfilled, for an operatic version of Shakespeare’s *King Lear*.



VERDI THEATRE, BUSSETO

The theater named after Verdi was inaugurated on August 15, 1868, with performances of *Un ballo in maschera* and *Rigoletto*. Verdi himself refused to attend.